

Meridian Health Insurance

Clinical Coverage Policy Manual

Medical Necessity Criteria for Prior Authorization Review

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This manual is a synthetic, fictional document created for software testing and model training purposes. It does not represent the policies of any real insurance company.

Lumbar Spine MRI (without contrast)

Policy Number: MHI-ORTHO-014 | Specialty: Orthopedics / Neurology | Diagnosis Codes: M51.26, M54.5, M51.16 | Procedure Codes: 72148

Approval Criteria (ALL of the following must be met)

- Documented low back pain or radiculopathy present for at least 6 consecutive weeks, AND
- At least one trial of conservative management attempted and failed (physical therapy, NSAIDs, or activity modification), AND
- One or more of the following: progressive neurological deficit, suspected cauda equina syndrome, or failure to improve after conservative therapy.

Not Medically Necessary / Denial Conditions

- Symptom duration less than 6 weeks without red-flag findings (progressive weakness, bowel/bladder dysfunction, trauma, suspected malignancy).
- No conservative treatment attempted or documented.

Required Documentation

Clinical notes documenting symptom duration and conservative treatment; Physical exam findings.

Biologic Disease-Modifying Antirheumatic Drugs (Adalimumab and similar agents)

Policy Number: MHI-RHEUM-007 | Specialty: Rheumatology | Diagnosis Codes: M06.9, M05.79 | Procedure Codes: J0135

Approval Criteria (ALL of the following must be met)

- Confirmed diagnosis of moderate-to-severe rheumatoid arthritis by a rheumatologist, AND
- Trial of at least one conventional DMARD (e.g., methotrexate) for a minimum of 3 months at an adequate dose, with inadequate response, AND
- Lab findings consistent with active disease (elevated ESR/CRP, or positive RF/anti-CCP) OR imaging evidence of joint damage.

Not Medically Necessary / Denial Conditions

- No conventional DMARD trial documented.
- Conventional DMARD trial duration less than 3 months without documented intolerance.

Required Documentation

Rheumatologist visit note; DMARD trial dates and dosing; Relevant labs.

Continuous Glucose Monitor (CGM)

Policy Number: MHI-ENDO-021 | Specialty: Endocrinology | Diagnosis Codes: E11.9, E10.9 | Procedure Codes: E2103

Approval Criteria (ALL of the following must be met)

- Confirmed diagnosis of diabetes mellitus (Type 1 or Type 2), AND
- Currently on multiple daily insulin injections OR insulin pump therapy, OR documented history of problematic hypoglycemia, AND

- HbA1c above target range despite current therapy, OR frequency of self-monitoring blood glucose insufficient to safely manage insulin dosing.

Not Medically Necessary / Denial Conditions

- Patient not on insulin therapy and no documented hypoglycemia history.
- HbA1c at goal on current regimen without hypoglycemia concerns.

Required Documentation

Recent HbA1c; Current medication/insulin regimen; Hypoglycemia history if applicable.

CGRP Inhibitor Therapy for Chronic Migraine (e.g., Erenumab)

Policy Number: MHI-NEURO-009 | Specialty: Neurology | Diagnosis Codes: G43.709 | Procedure Codes: J3032

Approval Criteria (ALL of the following must be met)

- Diagnosis of chronic migraine (≥ 15 headache days/month for ≥ 3 months), AND
- Failure of, intolerance to, or contraindication to at least two conventional preventive medication classes (e.g., beta-blockers, anticonvulsants, tricyclics), each trialed for at least 8 weeks at an adequate dose.

Not Medically Necessary / Denial Conditions

- Fewer than two conventional preventive medication trials documented.
- Trial duration under 8 weeks without documented intolerance.

Required Documentation

Headache diary or frequency documentation; Prior preventive medication trial history with dates/doses.

CPAP Therapy for Obstructive Sleep Apnea

Policy Number: MHI-PULM-011 | Specialty: Pulmonology | Diagnosis Codes: G47.33 | Procedure Codes: E0601

Approval Criteria (ALL of the following must be met)

- Diagnostic sleep study (in-lab polysomnography or home sleep apnea test) confirming Apnea-Hypopnea Index (AHI) ≥ 15 , OR AHI ≥ 5 with documented symptoms (excessive daytime sleepiness, hypertension, or cardiovascular disease).

Not Medically Necessary / Denial Conditions

- No diagnostic sleep study on file.
- AHI below 5, or AHI 5-14 without qualifying symptoms/comorbidities.

Required Documentation

Sleep study report with AHI value.

Transcranial Magnetic Stimulation (TMS) for Major Depressive Disorder

Policy Number: MHI-PSYCH-018 | Specialty: Psychiatry | Diagnosis Codes: F33.1, F32.9 | Procedure Codes: 90867

Approval Criteria (ALL of the following must be met)

- Confirmed diagnosis of major depressive disorder by a psychiatrist, AND
- Failure of at least two adequate antidepressant medication trials (different classes), each at least 6 weeks at a therapeutic dose, AND
- Concurrent or prior engagement in psychotherapy.

Not Medically Necessary / Denial Conditions

- Fewer than two antidepressant trials documented.
- No psychotherapy engagement documented.
- History of seizure disorder (contraindication) without further review.

Required Documentation

Psychiatrist evaluation; Medication trial history with dates/doses; Psychotherapy engagement notes.

Diagnostic Cardiac Catheterization

Policy Number: MHI-CARD-003 | Specialty: Cardiology | Diagnosis Codes: I25.10 | Procedure Codes: 93458

Approval Criteria (ALL of the following must be met)

- Positive or high-risk finding on non-invasive stress testing (stress echo, nuclear stress test, or stress ECG), OR
- Clinical presentation consistent with unstable angina or acute coronary syndrome, OR
- Emergent presentation with strong clinical suspicion of acute MI.

Not Medically Necessary / Denial Conditions

- No stress testing performed and no acute/unstable presentation documented.
- Low-risk or negative stress test result without other qualifying findings.

Required Documentation

Stress test report or ECG/troponin results; Clinical presentation notes.

Total Knee Arthroplasty (Knee Replacement)

Policy Number: MHI-ORTHO-022 | Specialty: Orthopedics | Diagnosis Codes: M17.11, M17.12 | Procedure Codes: 27447

Approval Criteria (ALL of the following must be met)

- Radiographic evidence of moderate-to-severe osteoarthritis (Kellgren-Lawrence Grade 3 or 4), AND
- Failure of at least 12 weeks of conservative management (physical therapy, NSAIDs, or intra-articular injection), AND
- Documented functional limitation impacting activities of daily living.

Not Medically Necessary / Denial Conditions

- Conservative management duration under 12 weeks without documented contraindication.
- Kellgren-Lawrence Grade 2 or lower without significant functional limitation.

Required Documentation

Radiology report with KL grade; Conservative treatment history with duration; Functional assessment (e.g., Oxford Knee Score).

Stimulant Medication for ADHD (Lisdexamfetamine and similar)

Policy Number: MHI-PSYCH-005 | Specialty: Psychiatry | Diagnosis Codes: F90.0, F90.1 | Procedure Codes: J8499

Approval Criteria (ALL of the following must be met)

- Confirmed ADHD diagnosis by a qualified prescriber using standardized diagnostic criteria, AND
- Trial of at least one alternative stimulant or non-stimulant medication with inadequate response or intolerance documented.

Not Medically Necessary / Denial Conditions

- No alternative medication trial documented.
- History of substance use disorder without additional safeguards documented.

Required Documentation

Diagnostic evaluation notes; Prior medication trial history.

Biologic Infusion Therapy for Crohn's Disease (Infliximab and similar)

Policy Number: MHI-GI-016 | Specialty: Gastroenterology | Diagnosis Codes: K50.90, K50.10 | Procedure Codes: J1745

Approval Criteria (ALL of the following must be met)

- Confirmed diagnosis of moderate-to-severe Crohn's disease (via endoscopy/imaging), AND
- Failure of, intolerance to, or contraindication to conventional therapy (aminosalicylates, immunomodulators such as azathioprine, or corticosteroids), AND
- Objective evidence of active inflammation (elevated fecal calprotectin, elevated CRP, or active findings on endoscopy/imaging).

Not Medically Necessary / Denial Conditions

- No conventional therapy trial documented.
- No objective evidence of active inflammation.

Required Documentation

Endoscopy/imaging report; Prior therapy trial history; Inflammatory markers (fecal calprotectin or CRP).
